without relying on such extrinsic factors as the author's background?

4. Orientation – Where does the work fit within the history of literary development? How does it relate to other works written by the same author? to works on the same subject by other authors? to comparable works of different time periods?
5. Valuation – Does the work have some general value - some unique value? Does it appeal to any special group or to most readers? Is the appeal limited in time or is it universal?
6. Generalisation – What broad, general statements can be made about the work?

Preparing to write the review

Now that you have some understanding and awareness of what constitutes a book review and what qualifications you will need as a reviewer, you are ready for the next step – preparation for the writing. This does not mean that you sit down and jot down whatever comes to mind, making your first draft your last draft. The emphasis here is on preparation, which is getting ready to write. Good writing requires preparation, organisation, writing, revision and rewriting.

Reading the work to be reviewed Here is a checklist you can use for your reading:

1. Avoid reading blurbs, summaries, and commentaries prior to the reading of the work.
2. Read only when you are fresh and alert.
3. Read with proper lighting and with a minimum of disturbances and interruptions.
4. Give careful thought to the title of the work and its significance and implication.
5. Read the preface to familiarise yourself with the author's intent.
6. Look over the table of contents (if there is one) so that you will be aware of the book's basic organisation.
7. Know the genre to which the book belongs so that you may judge the work accordingly.
8. Get your own copy of the work, if possible, so that you can read actively. If you use somebody else's book, then keep slips of paper available for jotting down your reactions. Insert these slips within the book.
9. Read the entire book. Get a general impression and think about the work. Let it lie fallow in your mind until you see it in proper perspective.
10. Read the work again, this time for details to substantiate your initial impression or to modify that impression.
11. Be thorough and perceptive in your reading so that you can be fair to the author.

A sample book review :

Frankenstein's Cat

Review by H Aslam, age 16, Washermanpet

I really loved Frankenstein's Cat for its fascinating explanation about the often baffling subject of bioengineering and other related sister sciences. Emily Anthes explains the many sides of today's modern technology, such as gene modification,

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